

THE COST OF JUSTICE ANTHOLOGY UNVEILED IN ABUJA, CALLS FOR URGENT REFORM IN WOMEN'S ACCESS TO JUSTICE



Abuja, Nigeria — Activities marking International Women's Day and Women's Month continued in Abuja with the official unveiling of *The Cost of Justice Anthology*, a literary and advocacy project drawing national attention to the barriers women face in accessing justice.

The anthology was developed by the South Saharan Social Development Organisation (SSDO) and officially launched in partnership with UN Women, with support from the Ford Foundation. The event brought together key stakeholders to examine systemic challenges and advocate for stronger, more inclusive justice systems for women and girls.

The launch, held at the United Nations House in Abuja, attracted high-level dignitaries, including representatives of the Honourable Minister for Women Affairs and the Honourable Minister for Justice, alongside representatives of embassies and development partners.



Also in attendance were Ms. Elsie Attafuah, UNDP Representative and Resident Coordinator ai; Ms. Muriel Mafico, Resident Representative of the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) in Nigeria; and Mrs. Beatrice Eyong, UN Women Representative to Nigeria and ECOWAS.

Dr. Adedayo Benjamins Laniyi, Mandate Secretary of the FCT Women Affairs Secretariat, joined civil society leaders, writers, and advocates at the event.

Speaking at the event, the UNDP Representative and Resident Coordinator ai, Elsie Attafuah, called on stakeholders to move beyond rhetoric and take concrete steps to ensure justice for women and girls.

She emphasized that justice must not remain an aspiration but must become a lived reality that is accessible, inclusive, and transformative.



Speaking at the launch, Dr. Stanley Ilechukwu, Executive Director of SSDO, emphasized that the anthology sheds light on the often-overlooked human cost borne by women when justice systems fail.

“This anthology brings to life the realities many women face, including the stigma, the silence, the financial burden, and the systemic barriers. It is both a reflection and a call to action for all stakeholders to strengthen accountability and ensure justice is accessible to every woman,” he said.



The Cost of Justice Anthology draws from community experiences gathered through the Sister Guardian Initiative, a women-led protection network established by SSDO to support survivors of gender-based violence. Through years of grassroots engagement, recurring stories of stigma, financial hardship, institutional delays, and barriers to justice emerged.

Following a nationwide call for submissions, over one hundred writers contributed stories exploring the emotional and financial toll of seeking justice. Selected entries were compiled into the anthology after a rigorous review process.

Speakers at the event called on governments, institutions, and communities to move beyond rhetoric and take concrete steps toward building justice systems that are accessible, affordable, inclusive, and responsive to the needs of women and girls.

Organisers say *The Cost of Justice Anthology* is a national call to action aimed at inspiring policy reform, strengthening institutional response, and advancing a justice system that works for all.

